were to be targeted off Luzon, so as to make Japan-based fighter coverage impossible.
- As a diversionary tactic, the North Sea Fleet, out of Qingdao, dispatched a flotilla of destroyers, frigates, and corvettes into the East China Sea, toward the Jeju and Korean Straits, hoping to draw off Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force ships (JMSDF) from supporting the US Navy.

The Taiwan Strait Is Lost

First blood in the expanded theater of operations was drawn by the Chinese on September 12. The USS *Stethem* and USS *Patriot*, previously ordered to transit the Taiwan Strait, were caught in a swarm of Chinese fishing craft, Type 22 PLAN missile patrol boats, and Chinese Coast Guard ships that had crossed the median line at a point about halfway through the strait. Slowed to a crawl by the swarm of small craft and alarmed by the threatening tactics from the boats, the *Stethem* felt forced to fire warning shots. This resulted in a missile swarm fired from the small PLAN patrol craft, which apparently had orders to attack the US ships if they gave any justification for doing so, such as firing their guns even in defense. The *Patriot* sustained casualties and serious damage, and the *Stethem*, while also sustaining damage, returned fire, disabling one of the CCG ships and several of the missile boats, and driving off the others. US Air Force F-22s operating out of Kadena (approximately 400 nm away) engaged with older Chinese J-10s and J-11s, which had been sent to harass the American vessels, destroying eight planes before breaking off. The *Stethem* and *Patriot* eventually broke free of the swarm and limped to Kaohsiung, Taiwan. This allowed Beijing to claim on September 13 that Taiwan was now a belligerent and to announce that the Taiwan Strait was closed, send a blockading force to Kaohsiung just outside Taiwan's twelve-mile territorial limit, position two more Type 052D destroyers for antiair missions over the Taiwan Strait, and begin multiple combat aerial patrols around the island. Taiwanese naval ships sent to meet the Chinese were